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124 | PRINCESS CAROLINE OF MONACO was one of Christian Louboutin's first customers when he opened his primary boutique on Rue Jean-Jacques Rousseau in Paris's posh Louvre District in 1991. Since then, fans of the Paris-born designer's iconic red-soled shoes have included the late Tina Turner, Jennifer Lopez (J.Lo), Beyoncé, Sarah Jessica Parker, and Taylor Swift, and Leonardo DiCaprio as well after the maison launched his men's footwear collection in 2010. The designer debuted his handbag collection in 2006, followed by a beauty line in 2014. Then in 2022, he launched the kids' range, making sure that tiny feet are also adorned with the famous red-soled shoes. Today, there are 165 Christian Louboutin stores worldwide, including two in India.

"India as a country never disappoints," he says, in a typically French-accented English drawl. "Other countries you get excited seeing a postcard, but when you reach [the country], it is not like that. India is the opposite; it is so much more than what you expect," says Louboutin, who first visited India as a 15-year-old. His love affair with the country began with Bollywood and other Indian regional cinema that he grew up watching in the Barbados. "The first movie I saw was Satyajit Ray's *Devi* with Sharmila Tagore," he says.

Over the years he has visited India several times, and while he says that being a global brand it is not possible to launch a collection that is specific to a country's taste, his love for India is visible in all his collections. "My love for India is in every one of my collections, I love colour," says the 60-year-old, adding "India is so detail-oriented that you can do an India-inspired collection for a 100 years without repeating yourself." That doesn't stop the brand from launching capsules specific to the India market, especially to target the \$50-billion

Indian wedding market. "There is nothing more colourful, more extravagant, and more glamorous, than an Indian wedding," he says. The exclusive capsule showcases a selection of the *maison's* icons—10 women's shoe styles, six men's shoe styles and two handbags—in a gradient of metallic hues of platinum, gold and bronze. The capsule is versatile and has options in a variety of heel heights to match both western and Indian silhouettes.

Louboutin says that different collections do well in different parts of the world. For instance, his collections in Los Angeles (LA) are very different from those in New York. "No one walks in LA;

